

Playing Around with Facebook Search the Geeky Way!

Social networking is here to stay and of all the social networking sites, Facebook is the *crème de la crème*. Let's learn how to search data on Facebook in a more efficient way.



Facebook launched its Graph Search feature in order to provide a new way of searching through Facebook's huge social graph. Facebook's Graph Search is generally accessed by using the search bar, but many are unaware that Facebook provides sophisticated RESTful APIs, which can revolutionise the way we search Facebook data. This API is publicly visible whenever you use the search bar.

Getting the JSON from Facebook

As the days of XML are gone, JSON has become the generic option for data exchange. Facebook stores a JSON string for all its objects. This string contains basic information and a description about the identifier provided. The identifier must be a unique identification link of any person, page, city, interest or any object in Facebook.

To get this JSON, use the URL <http://graph.facebook.com/identifier>

As an example, the following is the JSON string returned from <http://graph.facebook.com/OpenSourceForU> (*OpenSourceForU* is the identifier here):

```
{
  "id": "58079349432",
  "about": "The Complete Magazine On Open Source!",
  ...
  "username": "OpenSourceForU",
  "website": "http://www.opensourceforu.com",
}
```

An important element from the above JSON is *id* with a value of *58079349432*; this may be the primary key which is used by Facebook to query its databases. As we can see, *id* is always a numeric string. In further sections, we'll use this *id* to do all the searches and to generally play around.



Note: A Facebook object can be any entity like a person, page, interest, city, etc. It refers to just about anything on Facebook. However, it doesn't include comments or 'likes' as these are just properties of the objects.